Fun, wins, and losses

IMSC: J(1)-MK-1

By: MrMillerPink, edited by: koviubi

Introduction

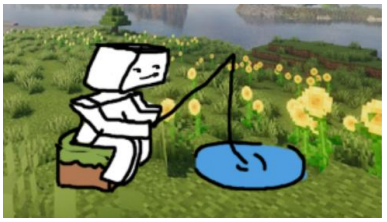
In activities of any kind, a type of win and loss will be present. Whether it is finishing your build in a building game, having it be destroyed, or finding loot in adventures. However, you may not recognize that winning can be a broad term applicable in many contexts, and the same can be said for losses. Both have their own consequences towards players. Thus, when designing Minecraft servers, one must be especially familiar with the topic so crucial to fun.

This article provides more clarification on fun, winning, and losing in videogames, highlighting key information I've learned throughout studying game design.



I. What is fun?

What I've noticed during my time in the Institute of Minecraft Studies (IMS) Discord server, is the rather arbitrary understanding most people have of fun. Fun is not exclusive to a specific activity like socialization, player interaction, rivalry, or teamwork! There are many ways to have fun and players prefer different activities. Therefore, excluding other activities by entirely dedicating our research to a few would be delinquent.



We need a definition of fun for this article to even exist. I'll be using Gabe Newell's "ad hoc definition" of fun which he stated in an interview.[1] Gabe Newell is the CEO of Valve, an American video game developer, publisher, hardware, and digital distribution company. He is a competent game designer and was involved in the making of the corporation's earliest games. He and his team defined fun as "the degrees to which the game recognizes and responds to the players' choices and actions".



This definition is the best one I know. Some degree of time and effort is put into every choice the player makes: be it walking, breaking blocks, fighting monsters, etc. It's really important for game designers to reward players for their efforts, as it's the basis for fun to take place. Players want to feel that their choices and work have meaning and impact to the world around them, so we should make their impact apparent.

II. Wins and losses

It's easier to explain wins by analyzing the ones in Minecraft. When you build a makeshift shelter on your first night, win a pillager raid, or even kill a single spider, that's a win! Wins come in different sizes and forms, and people seek out and enjoy different types of activities.

However, wins can feel empty if we don't give them impact or reward. When you fight and loot trial chambers, it's satisfying because you made the decision to fight, you beat the challenges, and dealt with the risk of losing your items; when you finally beat it, you get a reward! In this situation, the player had agency, information was properly communicated, and most players felt fairly compensated by the end of it.

It's a fundamental skill in game design to reward and show a player's work. Too little or no reward will make activities feel pointless, and if it's mandatory, it'll feel like doing chores. Too much could make a reward not feel earned or desensitize the player's feeling of reward.

However, getting swiftly blown up by a falling creeper, getting pestered by phantoms, or accidentally throwing your items into lava also feels frustrating. Why? Even if it technically was the player's fault, they were given no awareness or agency, and they were punished by something they didn't do or did unintentionally. This feels unfair!

Players should be able to tell why they lost, at least in hindsight, and they should absolutely be given ways to deal with their issues. Minecraft isn't a great example of this as the game has issues of being too soft or just annoying; so another game must be used as an example.



III. An example of fair wins and losses

Risk of Rain 2 is a roguelike fighting game with a unique mechanic: the more time a player spends the stronger the enemies become. To avoid the enemies becoming far stronger than the player, said player must perform a balancing act of collecting and purchasing loot around the stage by killing enemies to gain coins, while also progressing through the game by getting to the next stage to collect and buy more loot.

Taking too long to get more powerful or excessively searching a singular stage for the last chests/items has led to the death of many. However, players can leave any time they want (though they'll have to defeat a boss to earn their progression). This, alongside the many other measures the game has to help it feel fairer, has made *Risk of Rain 2* feel surprisingly fair, especially for a game in the *roguelike* genre, which is home to a lot of randomization outside the player's control.

The enemies are also very well designed. They often appear in large crowds, yet somehow you have a good understanding of what's happening around you when you fight. Information is adequately communicated to players, and that will help make deaths feel fairer and a result of their own incompetence rather than a fault of the game.

That fairness combined with the reward of getting incredibly strong items as a result of your skill and smart decisions, and seeing enemies you once struggled with get defeated easily make *Risk of Rain 2* a very enjoyable experience.

Although it's a game that strays far from Minecraft's gameplay, the ways it approached its gameplay are exemplary when viewed in its whole.

IV. The cost of competitive multiplayer

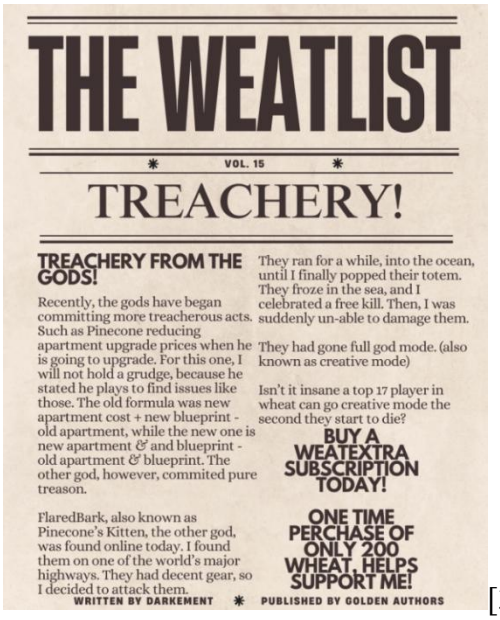
Another example is Fortnite. Competitive games with multiplayer can be very fun if done right! The loss feels real and it's a true test of your skill and decision making that comes with satisfying victories. It may also create interaction with others in the form of rivalries that amplify satisfaction, and also through strong teamwork that strengthens the connection between people.

However, there is a hidden cost inherent to it. In a competitive multiplayer environment, there has to be a loser. In a game of Fortnite, one player has to be 100th place, which feels embarrassing. Half of the players won't make it to the top 50. Only one player or group can be 1st. Losing sucks! People need to win more than they lose to have fun, but in Fortnite, there will always be a loser. The people behind the game made bots to counteract this, and it came with understandable backlash from the community.[2] Competitive multiplayer is expected to be exactly that: competitive and multiplayer. Adding bots to where players expect real people disrupts the premise and promise of fighting other humans, not a machine.

The playstyle that was advertised and supported in Raid Farms were alliances and rivalries, but that meant the destruction of one group in favor of another. This is yet another issue of Raid Farms and anarchy in general, the core gameplay involves discouraging players from continuing to play. In anarchy Minecraft servers, there is an expectation of hostility among the

players in the form of fighting or griefing. However, these activities that come at the cost of another player's enjoyment. There was an infamous incident of corruption in Raid Farms involving a normal player encountering Pinekitten, a person close to Pinecone, the YouTuber and owner of Raid Farms. The player attempted to kill her, but she was saved by intervention from Pinecone. Afterwards, the player was banned.

This event is clear proof that Pinecone has faced the issue inherent to competitive multiplayer: enjoyment deriving from another person's loss. He resorted to intervening with cheats to resolve it, which led to the person who attempted to kill Pinekitten, and perhaps even more, to leave.



THE WEATLIST

VOL. 15

TREACHERY!

TREACHERY FROM THE GODS!

Recently, the gods have began committing more treacherous acts. Such as Pinecone reducing apartment upgrade prices when he is going to upgrade. For this one, I will not hold a grudge, because he stated he plays to find issues like those. The old formula was new apartment cost + new blueprint - old apartment, while the new one is new apartment & and blueprint - old apartment & blueprint. The other god, however, commited pure treason.

FlaredBark, also known as Pinecone's Kitten, the other god, was found online today. I found them on one of the world's major highways. They had decent gear, so I decided to attack them. They ran for a while, into the ocean, until I finally popped their totem. They froze in the sea, and I celebrated a free kill. Then, I was suddenly un-able to damage them. They had gone full god mode. (also known as creative mode)

Isn't it insane a top 17 player in wheat can go creative mode the second they start to die?

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[3]



THE WEATLIST

THE END

BANNED.

BANNED.

As you probably already know, I've been banned from both the discord server and the world. It was fun while it lasted, and maybe I'll play on RaidFarms 2.0 if that ever happens, and if I'm unbanned.

I will say, though, that I simply don't regret my actions yesterday. Playing on a server where the admins can just cheat into creative mode when they start to die isn't fun.

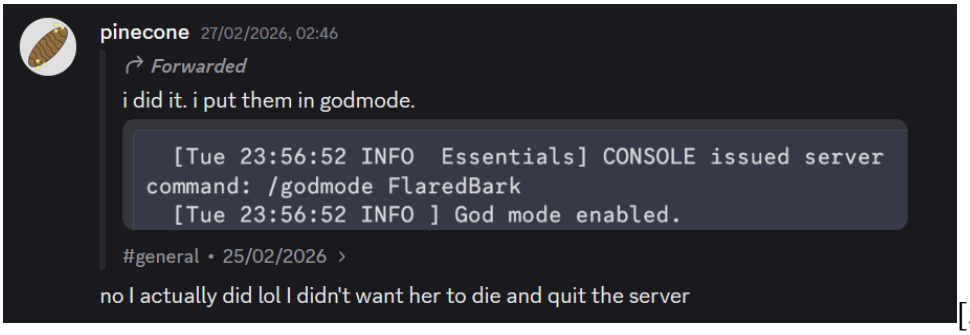
In honor of Weat, I've posted the weat collage finale with this weatlist.

Maybe on RaidFarms 2, Il post more weatlists.

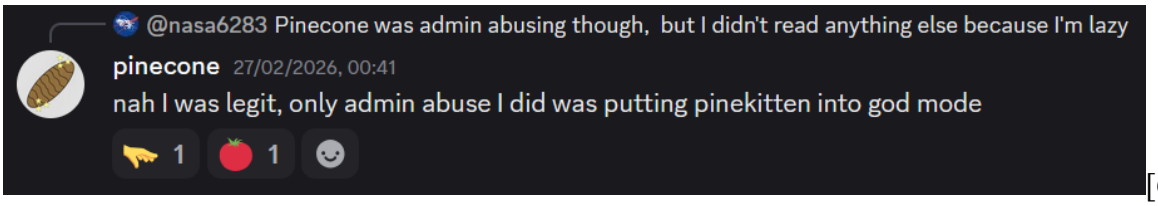
AT LEAST I WAS SACRIFICED TO PLEASE THE WEAT GODS.

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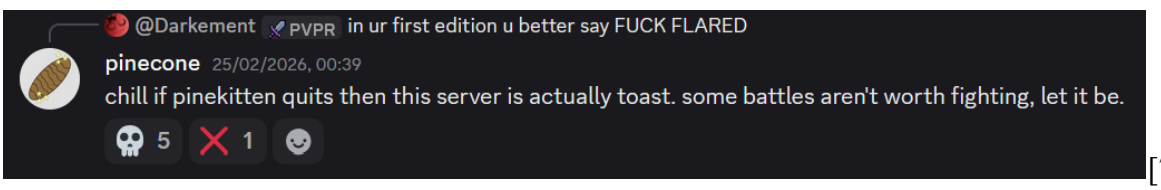
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V. Conclusion and closing thoughts

Game design is the core of making games, as it's the method and adequacy of which a game is made in order to achieve its goals. That is why I believe that more game design discussions are needed in the MSTI, as it's being disregarded – even though studying it will improve our understanding and ways of addressing issues regarding MST.

Although you may think I'm against competitive multiplayer, I'm not! Competitions can make winning feel more rewarding, like Super Mario Bros, which is a widely successful game, even though it has a strong competitive aspect. Such a game simply has to address the issues that the losers face.

References

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